

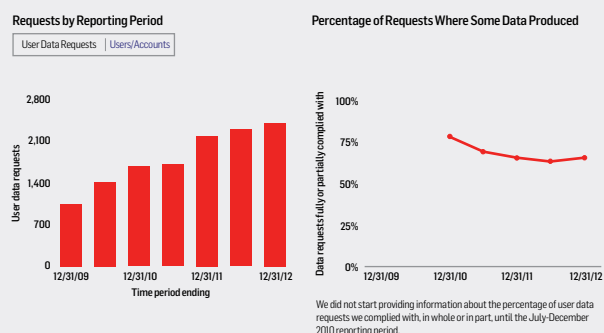
Privacy in India

The Indian government has also seen fit to go after private companies in search of your data, just like the NSA. Transparency reports released this year by Google, Facebook and Twitter reveal how interested the government is in the going ons in social media. According to Google's transparency report released this year, India was the country that made the second most number of data requests from the search giant (over a period spanning July to December 2012) at 2,431 requests about 4,106 users, 66% of which resulted in some data being handed over to the government. In comparison, the US, ranked number one on the list, made 8,438 requests about 14,868 users on Google with an 88% 'success rate' while France came in third with 1,693 requests about 2,063 users of which only 44% were handed over. India's numbers have only grown from the previous transparency report which showed that from January to June 2012, the Indian government made 2,319 data requests on 3,467 users with a 64% 'success rate'.

Moving on to Facebook, here too the Indian government ranks second, only outmatched by the US' desire to spy on its own citizens. From January to June 2013, India made 3,245 data requests about 4,144 user accounts of which Facebook was able to hand over 50% of the requested data. Germany falls a distant third with about 58% of India's data requests. Twitter, on the other hand, has seen not seen too much attention from the government but we should accord that to the fact that rarely is Twitter used for private communication, rather than a sudden change of heart up top.

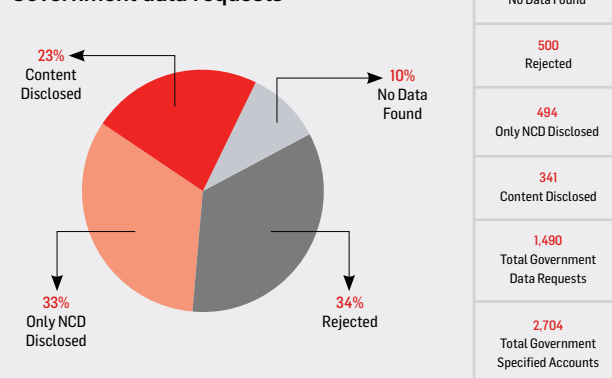
In its transparency report that spans the first half of 2013 (January to June), Yahoo has revealed that India made the seventh most data requests globally with a total of 1,490 requests for 2,704 user accounts, of which 341 requests were handled by disclosing the content of the information while some data on 494 requests was revealed to the government.

Summary of requests



An image showing data requests made to Google by Indian government

Government data requests



An image showing data requests made to Yahoo by Indian government

government essentially can sift through all the data generated on the Internet by the 160 million odd users who go online regularly in our country.

While the government has asked ISPs to appoint nodal officers to liaise with the government regarding what data

help from any of these ISPs. As a result, as the Hindu found out, none of the major Indian ISPs have bothered to install the LIM systems at their end or even appoint nodal officers. There also don't seem to be any legal safeguards with an eye out for user privacy in place, although

an amendment that gave the government even more power to intercept, monitor and decrypt online communication for reasons of 'national security'.

But wait, there's more! Right out of the pages of a story written by someone who could only be the love-child of Stephen King and George Orwell, comes the Central Monitoring System (CMS), India's answer to PRISM, an amorphous surveillance system that would put both Skynet and Shodan to shame, put together by the Centre for Development of Telematics (C-DOT). The data collected from the CMS will be put to use by India's intelligence agencies, Indian Revenue Service (for monitoring tax collections) and by the NATGRID (National Intelligence Grid), an interconnected integrated database for all intelligence services in India.

"The Central Monitoring System (CMS) is India's answer to PRISM, an amorphous surveillance system that would put both Skynet and Shodan to shame."

is required and whether its legal (and feasible) to pull it out, for all intents and purposes that's a moot point, since the government doesn't actually require any

privacy is protected under Section 419A of the Indian Telegraph Rules 1951 and the Information Technology Act of 2000 (before it was mutilated in 2008 through